

Company: ISS-STOXX

Job Profile: Software Engineer

Offer type: Internship + Placement

Internship Stipend: 60k

CTC: 12.9 Base + 1.1 (PF and Gratuity) = 14L + Variable bonus (not mentioned yet)

Location: Nesco IT Park, Goregaon, Mumbai

Process Date: 04-08-2025 PPT

05-08-2025 OA + Interviews

Background:

First of all, let me just say — the placement journey is **not easy at all**. Some people might crack it in their first go, while others have to go through multiple attempts. And honestly, not everyone admits how much **luck** is involved in these processes. Yes, your preparation matters a lot, but once you've put in your 100% effort, a lot of it still comes down to timing, panel, and randomness.

Let me walk you through my own experiences — the only companies where I cleared the OA and got to the interview stage were **UBS, MSCI, IDFC, Nomura**, and finally **ISS** (which was my 5th shot).

- **UBS:**

This was my first interview experience. I realized during the process that my prep wasn't fully up to the mark — especially in terms of depth — and I got rejected in Round 2. It was a learning experience that made me go back and revise.

- **MSCI:**

This one was a painful lesson. The process went quite well, and I was confident. I was asked two DSA questions:

1. *Left view of a binary tree*
2. *Total number of paths from (0,0) to (n-1,m-1) in a matrix*

I solved both correctly and even wrote the optimal code on paper in C++. Still, I wasn't shortlisted for the 2nd round. Why? Probably because I **delayed my interview**.

MSCI interviews and EDS OA were scheduled on the same day. I chose to schedule my MSCI interview from 10:30 to 11:30 AM but ended up giving it around 1:30 PM

due to delays. In that time, others had already finished multiple rounds. So **please never delay your interview if given a choice** — they often try to cut down candidates and will nitpick reasons to reject you.

- **IDFC:**

Here, I faced a technical rejection due to being underprepared on in-depth **OOPs concepts** in both C++ and Java. I used C++ mostly for DSA and Java for OOPs, but I hadn't explored the **Java Collections Framework** properly, which hurt me in the interview.

- **Nomura (Global Markets role):**

This one went quite far — I cleared the **GD** (topic: *Is AI making us smarter or dependent?*), **Tech Round 1**, **Tech Round 2**, and even had my **first HR round**. But here I messed up by getting nervous and over-explaining in every answer.

Key takeaway: Be calm, **answer exactly what's asked**, and **don't give extra details** unless needed. Sometimes oversharing leads to follow-up questions you're not ready for, or just gives a poor impression.

After a month of rejections and learnings, I finally came to the **ISS** process with a better mindset and preparation.

Placement Process:

A total of 3 rounds were conducted - 1 Online Assessment Round, 1 Tech Interview Round & Finally 1 HR Round. All were conducted on the same day 5/08/25. The CGPA Criteria for SDE was 8.5, later reduced to 8. It was further reduced to 7.5. May not be the case for next year if they don't want more applicants, so it is preferable to maintain a pointer of 8.5 and above.

(I have included CGPA)

1. Resume/CGPA Shortlisting: (In this case it was CGPA shortlisting, but still I have provided guidance for Resume shortlisting)

Always tailor your resume to align with the specific job description of the role you're applying for. These adjustments don't need to be major — simply swapping a project, updating certifications, or modifying the skills section can make a significant difference.

Ensure that your resume maintains visual and structural consistency. Avoid mixing date formats, bullet styles, or using bold/italic formatting inconsistently across sections. A clean, well-organized resume gives a strong first impression.

Once your resume is finalized, evaluate its compatibility with Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS). Tools like [Resume Worded](#) can help — aim for a score of 65 or above.

Initially, the CGPA eligibility criteria for this role was set at 8.5, but it was later relaxed to 7.5. The shortlist of candidates selected for the Online Assessment and Pre-Placement Talk (PPT) was released on 3rd August 2025 at 7:00 PM.

2. Pre-Placement Talk:

The Pre-Placement Talk was conducted online on 4th August 2025 at 5:00 PM.

The information shared during Pre-Placement Talks is extremely valuable, so it's important to be attentive — not just to the content of the presentation, but also to the names and roles of the presenters. I made it a point to take multiple screenshots and jot down the specific examples used while the speaker explained some of the company's financial services. These details often come in handy during interviews.

While it's a good idea to ask thoughtful questions at the end of the session, it's even smarter to hold back a few insightful ones. Save them for your interview — this gives you an opportunity to show continued curiosity and engagement with the company during later stages.

3. Online Assessment: *(Approx. 160 students appeared, invigilated by the company)*

The online assessment comprised 70 questions to be completed in 90 minutes. It was conducted via Google Forms at the college premises. The marking scheme awarded +1 for each correct answer and imposed a -0.25 penalty for incorrect ones. The assessment covered four major sections: Java, Python, SQL, and Aptitude.

Java (18 Questions):

This section focused heavily on fundamental OOP concepts in Java. Topics included the Collection Framework (TreeMap, HashMap, LinkedHashMap, ConcurrentHashMap, ArrayList), access modifiers, threads and multithreading, keywords like synchronized and volatile, compile-time and runtime polymorphism, interfaces, abstract classes, exception handling, enums, and functional methods like map, filter, and reduce.

Most questions were of the “guess the output” type. Although my primary DSA language is C++, I had thoroughly studied and revised Java concepts beforehand. A great resource for MCQ practice:

[Java Practice - Sanfoundry](#)

Python (17 Questions):

Similar to Java, the Python section included “guess the output” questions involving OOP concepts, inheritance and MRO (Method Resolution Order), shallow vs deep copies, list comprehensions, slicing, dictionaries, sets, stacks, and queues. Many questions required careful dry runs and a strong grasp of Python's internal behavior and edge cases.

A good practice resource:

[Python Practice - Sanfoundry](#)

SQL (5 Questions):

This section tested practical SQL query-writing skills. The difficulty level was moderate, with questions based on GROUP BY, JOIN, ORDER BY, UPDATE, DELETE, and various date functions. Some tricky questions involved updating joined or aggregated tables. Attempt only if

confident.

Highly recommended:

[Top 50 SQL Questions - LeetCode](#)

Aptitude (30 Questions):

This was arguably the most challenging section. It covered clock problems, speed and distance, trigonometry, upstream-downstream problems, probability, combinatorics, statistics, geometry, family relationships, and financial mathematics (including stocks and investments).

Some questions were quite verbose and difficult to interpret, and I couldn't solve a few. Two great resources for aptitude practice are:

- [YouTube Aptitude Series by CareerRide](#)
- [IndiaBix Aptitude Practice](#)

I performed well in the Java, Python, and SQL sections but found the Aptitude section challenging. In total, I attempted around 50–55 out of 70 questions. Fortunately, I was among the 44 students shortlisted out of 160.

Final Tips:

Keep your technical concepts in Java and Python fresh, practice aptitude regularly to build speed, and remain calm under pressure. Time constraints will challenge everyone equally—focus on accuracy, avoid panic, and read questions carefully.

4. Technical Round 1: [44 student appeared] 2 interviewers in my panel

As I mentioned earlier, I was unsure of whether I'd be selected for interviews or not. So, I was keeping my cool and doing last minute revisions for Java. Around 12:15 pm we received the shortlists and I was delighted to see my name at the 17th position. I quickly had a small snack before the interviews start so that I am not empty stomach (make sure to eat at least a little and not be completely empty stomach due to stress/tension).

I was very lucky with my interview slot and timings, I was scheduled for 2nd interview in my panel. My interview lasted about 30-40 minutes. And there were 2 interviewers in my panel. Even if your interview gets scheduled late, don't worry and do your best.

I will keep my experience as detailed as possible.

I entered the cabin and greeted both the panelists, they asked me about my name and branch (Didn't ask me to introduce myself). They asked me why did I choose Data Science branch. I was honest and said that during that time I was naïve and wanted to pursue a career in data science without much understanding of it, I basically explained how I understood and explored other options and found my interest in software development. They asked me what backend technologies I had explored, I had done Node.js + Express framework and Django in python. He disappointedly asked whether I had not tried Java for backend. I answered this question very carefully and told him that I had studied Java for my

2nd Sem and then I had developed games like Snake and minesweeper using Java, and like justified that I know Java. Whereas for backend development my fundamentals are clear enough that switching the language won't be an issue for me. He was happy with my response.

Then he shifted the interview towards Java OOPs, He showed me one of the question from Java section in OA.

```
import java.util.HashMap;

class Person{
    String name;
    Person(String name){
        this.name = name;
    }
}

class Main {
    public static void main(String[] args) {
        Person p1 = new Person("Alice");
        Person p2 = new Person("Alice");

        HashMap<Person, Integer> mp = new HashMap<>();

        mp.put(p1, 100);
        mp.put(p2, 200);

        System.out.println(mp.size()+" "+mp.get(p1));
    }
}
```

He started asking whether do I see something wrong in Class Person or a way we can make it better. I suggested making **string private and having getter and setter method** to ensure that the name string is not directly accessible from outside of class and only via getter and setter method. He asked me which concept was OOPs is this, I answered Encapsulation and explained what it meant in this scenario.

He then asked me about the output of the code, I answered "2 100". Later they asked me how can I make the output to be 1 100. So, I suggested **overriding equals and hashCode** methods provided my HashMap class in Person class to behave such that if the name is equal, It will treat it as same object otherwise as different object. He also asked to improve the declaration of HashMap object. At first, I couldn't understand what exactly was needed to be done, I suggested having Person class object be immutable as there is a risk of key getting corrupted due to change in data within a Person object. Then they asked a follow up on what is a immutable class, I explained how to make a class immutable and also mentioned about enums. For the earlier question, Later they give me hints and I understood and explained that having a **ref of parent and object of child class is a better practice in Java**, as you can change the object to any other child of the parent without having to change the ref.

```
Map<Person, Integer> mp = new HashMap<>();
```

was the answer they were looking for. I needed hints but I caught on to it at the very end. They asked me to write a very simple program to remove all the white spaces from a string and return the string. I requested whether I could use C++, and I wrote it on piece of paper, I started by writing `#include<stdio.h>` but they said it's fine and write the logic, so I made a function with proper name like `removeWhiteSpaces` and passed in the string and simply iterated over it and checked whether if the character is non space then append it to ans string and return ans. The interviewer commented that he liked how I made a function instead of writing in Main.

Then they asked me about a simple SQL query involving a join and order by and limit to get the first row. I also said that it's possible to use `max(date)` to get the row with latest date.

The interview questions ended on a brighter note.

Questions I asked to interviewers:

1. I asked them to introduce themselves and their role.
2. How is AI being integrated within ISS and what's its impact has been for ISS. (I tried to enter the convo when they jokingly said that people in the company sometimes don't understand their own code as they use AI and that is why they do code reviews. Here I tried to showcase how I personally use AI as more of a tutor for learning and deep diving into concepts)
3. I don't remember exactly how but they were talking about data scrapping, and I took the opportunity and I replied that I have experience with data scrapping as well and how I made a script to scrape linkedIn profile data from their user urls using selenium and beautiful soup.

By the end of this, they asked me where do I stay and whether commute will be a problem.

And just after 10 minutes of leaving the cabin at 2 pm, I was notified that I have been shortlisted for next round.

Why I Think I Got Selected:

- **Timing & Luck:** I got an early interview slot, which helped.
- **Confidence & Communication:** I stayed composed and articulated my thoughts clearly.
- **Honesty:** I was transparent about what I knew and didn't.
- **Engagement:** I asked meaningful questions and engaged in a two-way conversation.

Even if you don't know something don't stay completely silent and keep processing your thoughts out and don't panic. Your personality and confidence also matters, try to work on soft skills and effective communication. Give as much mock interviews as you can to better prepare yourself.

In total 15 students were shortlisted for HR round including me.

Tips:

- Do not lie on your Resume but you can smartly change phrases so that your resume looks good.
- Do not throw the sheets/papers in which you did your OA questions. They can be asked in an interview.
- Make sure if you are adding any links then they are clickable in your resume
- Prepare well around your resume projects & its tech stack. You can ask your friend to keep on cross questioning you on them
- Prepare a couple of scenarios (even if fake) about disagreement in the team, or any times that you have shown leadership/ team spirit. These questions are very common too.
- If you don't know the answer or you are not able to recall it, try to put it across politely instead of saying something wrong
- Think out loud when solving a DSA problem/ SQL query but when saying a theory answer try to sort of structure it in your mind first. Make use of technical terms & examples where possible

5. HR Round: [15 students Appeared] 2 panelists

My HR round started at around 3:50 pm, I had prepared in advance for all the common HR questions which could be asked. Even if you get caught off guard do not panic and be calm and collected, answer it genuinely. My HR round lasted for about 30 minutes.

I entered the room and greeted the interviewers, their first question was do you know us. I had paid attention to PPT so I knew their names and I had mentioned that their cameras were not working properly so I didn't realize it instantly but by listening to their voice. They first asked me about my education from 10th, 12th and College CGPA and Cet score. I answered the question by making a narrative about how I wasn't very studious and how I got serious about studies and answered each question. They asked me about my family background, make sure to answer only what is needed and not more than that. I showcased how being a single child, my parents have been supportive and available for me. She also asked whether I knew the office location and visited the NESCO IT park, I replied with correct answer and was honest that I hadn't been there.

She asked me about why did I pursue CSE DS, I again answered genuinely and told her the truth. She asked me about my 1st coding project, I mentioned I had gotten into game development using Unity and later using Java built snake and minesweeper games. She also asked me about masters and would I want to pursue it. I answered no (I genuinely hadn't planned for masters) mentioned that how skills, experience and practical knowledge in industry is required to stay relevant and masters is more theoretical and academia focussed. So, I would rather up skill myself while working in a job. She pressed on even more about the fact that aren't my parents insisting for me to do masters since I am a single child. Again, I thought carefully and answered that it was different during my father's time where a degree was required to grow in pharmaceutical companies. Whereas in tech I don't need as much

education, **having experience and skills are the most important thing**. (Try to justify the trade off between masters and job)

How do I stay relevant about the tech news. I said **Youtube, Reddit, Twitter and justified my perspective**. She started asking me about my perspective about AI, I made sure to answer everything positively. I said AI is a tool and won't completely replace a human, at least not until there is a very fundamental change in how AI works. I made sure to cover the positive aspects of AI, she said would it have any impact on jobs? And I said that due to this for example 10 people doing some work would be reduced to 5-6, but there could be other jobs for managing agentic AI systems. She asked me how would I make sure I don't get replaced with AI. I again answered that **not staying in the comfort zone** for a long time is the key and always having continuous growth and learning is essential.

She also asked me about my hobbies, I answered **reading, table tennis, badminton, swimming**. I made sure to elaborate on how reading was not my strong point and how I developed that skill effectively. Sir had only asked me a single question about what is my preference regarding **application developer and AIML**. I made sure to answer diplomatically, I said my primary focus is on developing software either for clients or for some internal company usage, and within software development I want to keep my options broader and so that I am able to figure out my interests, etc. And how I could maybe help others get a new perspective in software development processes using my ML and Gen AI knowledge, so no knowledge ever goes waste.

She lastly asked where do I stay and whether commute would be a problem for me. I live in thane so I said it won't be a big issue for me as I have been travelling for SPIT for the past 3 years. And if I do find it difficult, I would simply shift closer towards the company and ensure it doesn't hamper my work.

I made sure to ask decent questions:

1. How is **data staleness** managed as old data cannot be served to clients
2. Since ISS is multi-national company serving over 15+ countries, how do they manage and maintain **regulatory compliance** for each country.
3. How does team and project allotment work for interns and freshers in ISS

HR Interview Tips:

1. **Maintain Eye Contact**
Ensure steady, natural eye contact with the interviewer. It shows confidence and helps build a connection, but avoid staring as it may come across as forced.
2. **Be Mindful of What You Share**
Avoid oversharing personal experiences that don't directly address the question. Focus on relevant, concise answers that highlight your suitability for the role.

3. **Use the STAR Method**

Structure your answers to behavioral questions using the STAR method (Situation, Task, Action, Result). It provides clarity and demonstrates a problem-solving mindset.

4. **Show Respect in All Responses**

Be polite and professional. Even casual or off-topic comments should be delivered respectfully to avoid unintentionally offending the interviewer.

5. **Frame Strengths and Weaknesses as Narratives**

Share your strengths and weaknesses with context. Use short stories or examples (real or carefully crafted) that showcase growth and self-awareness.

6. **Avoid Monologues**

Don't treat your answers like speeches. Keep the conversation balanced, concise, and interactive. Know when to stop and where to elaborate.

7. **Display Confidence and Personality**

Strong communication and soft skills often outweigh technical skills in HR rounds. Let your personality come through—be confident, composed, and clear.

8. **Always be Positive**

Always answer all questions in a positive manner and I'll suggest don't ask for feedback in an HR interview, you can in a technical round if you feel that you've done great.

9. **Always Deny plans for Higher Studies**

Never show interest or accidentally hint your passion for academia and research. Prepare solid reasons to justify why you're choosing industry over academia, or it may become your reason for rejection.

Lastly, 12 students were selected out of 15, including myself. 2 for Data quality, 2 for software testing, 8 for Software Engineering.

Useful Tips:

- Make short notes for Core Concepts of OOPS, SQL, DBMS, OS, CN
- I used AI tools like ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, DeepSeek, Perplexity etc for various tasks like research about a topic, As a personal tutor, Help with projects, Deep diving into concepts, Interview practice and preparation.
- Make sure to practice your intro well with friends but make it seem that you are saying it extempore
- Prepare your resume well, make sure you know at least the basics of all technologies that you are putting there

- Have a general idea of all projects & your role etc. But practice one project in deep & use it everywhere for questioning & cross questioning
- Use an ATS Friendly Overleaf Resume Template ([My Resume](#) for Reference)
- Lastly, do not lose hope if you are not selected, keep on trying !

I have provided detailed tips and tricks within each section of my experience. Just work hard and you will succeed eventually, it's never over until you give up. **ALL THE BEST!!!**

Feel free to reach out in case of any queries : Aryan Kanyawar +91 9167726737 , [Linkedin](#)